

A FEMININE CRUSOE.

HOW SHE LIVED EIGHTEEN YEARS ON A DESERT ISLAND.

The Story of the Last Woman of San Nicolas—Her Ingenuity and Facility
of Invention—A Wonderful
Fol History.

[COr. Rochester Democrat.]

Seventy miles from the shore is San Nicolas Island, the sixth of the group that clusters around the bay of Santa Barbara, California. It is celebrated for having been the residence for eighteen years of "The Last Woman of San Nicolas." As her name is famous, and as her story has been told in romance, I will give the bare facts about her as I found them to be, without any added ornament, and leave the fiction to the pen of the novelist.

The island of San Nicolas was once densely populated. This is attested by the skulls and bones and other evidences of human abode that are found there. The Alaska Indians frequently visited the island to hunt for the fur of the sea-otter. They took their women with them on these hunts, and on returning after the hunt was over they left them on the island to their fate. By order of the government, in 1891, the Indians were removed from the island. Just before they were to embark, and carry away every human inhabitant, as it was supposed, a white Indian woman begged the privilege of going ashore for her child, which she had accidentally left. She was gone a long time in a fruitless search for her offspring. The wind blew a gale, the water was shallow; there was no one who was seeking the lost one. They set sail, intending to return for the last woman of San Nicolas, but the

one. They set sail, intending to return for the lost woman of San Nicolas, but the boat becoming unseaworthy, she was left to her fate. It was generally known that there was a woman abandoned on the island, but no attempt was made for her deliverance. As the world soon forgot, so the woman of San Nicolas was forgotten, and the years passed away. After a lapse of sixteen years a man who landed on the island found that it was inhabited by some one. The footprints of a human being sunk deep in the ground were seen. The hardness of the ground was an indication that they had been made a long time. From their size they evidently belonged to a woman. Circular inclosures made of brush, six or seven feet through, were seen, where some one had lived. Near the huts were sticks driven in the ground and dried blubber hanging on them, thus prepared for food.

In 1858 San Nicolas was visited again and another hunt was made for the long-lost woman. The huts were seen that had been seen before, but the old blubber had been taken away, and new food of the kind hung in its place. Wild dogs were found which ran away at the approach of civilized man. In a basket covered with seal skin that they found in a bush-heap was a dress made of sheep skin, cut in square pieces, a top made of silver and several smaller articles, such as fishbones and bone needles. The discoverers of these proofs that there lived on that island a human being scattered them on the ground, and on their return they found them gathered together and placed in the basket again.

The Catholic fathers of the "Old Mission," the foremost in every good word and work, offered a reward to anyone who would find the lost woman, and a third effort was made in 1860 to discover the prodigal about whom there was such a mystery and in whom the world of this coast was beginning to take an interest. Fresh tracks of the woman were

interest. Fresh tracks of the women were found. They belonged to very small feet, and were like those that were seen in the first attempt to find the women. Huts made of whale ribs and covered with bark were discovered. At length an object was seen in the distance that appeared to be moving. Going toward it they saw the woman that for eighteen years had reigned queen of the Nivkhas, her subjects being the wild animals, her robe a dress of birdskins she had made, and her throne the bark she had built. She was seated in an inclosure, so that only head and shoulders could be seen. Two or three dogs were about her that disappeared at the command of their sovereign. She was seated on some grass that covered the ground and served her as a bed. Her dress was mostly made of birdskins, extending to her ankles, the feathers of which were pointed downward. Her head was covered with a thick mat of yellowish-brown hair, and her shoulders were bare. She was occupied in stripping bladder from a piece of sealskin which she held across her knee, and using for that purpose a knife made of an iron hoop. In her hut was a fire, beside which she sat, talking to herself, and occasionally shaking her eyes with her hand, looked at the men that were in search of her.

She received them with much courtesy, bowing and smiling and showing that this lost child of nature had much of the politeness of a true woman. She took some roots in the bag, roasted them in the fire, and gave them to the men to eat. She gathered up all her food, which was her chief concern, owing to the famine she had experienced, washed herself at the spring, and followed the men cheerfully to the boat. On being taken to Santa Barbara she manifested great delight in seeing the signs of civilization. She became a universal favorite, and was presented with many gifts.

the island and proceeded with steady gait. Passengers on the Panama steamer that landed there all wanted to see the lost woman of San Nicolas. She related by signs her experience on the island, as she spoke a language that some of the Indians knew and some of the Spanish fathers, turned in Indian dialects, could understand. Civilization, which prolongs the life of some, shortened that of the woman of San Nicolas. An excessive love of fruit led to her death in Santa Barbara at the age of 55. She was buried with the honors of the Catholic church by the Franciscan fathers, and her dress and trinkets were sent to Rome and placed in that receptacle of the world's curiosities.

The story of the lost woman of San Nicolas will always remain a wonderment. Her ingenuity is seen in the pails she made of gourd, made to hold water by securing them with melted asphaltum, and in her birdskin dresses, her bone needles, her knife of iron hoop, and the language she invented and spoke. It is incredible to all who have learned her story how a woman could live eighteen years on an island around which the waves were beating a region to hope, getting her food and cooking it without even those facilities which are common to the savage, and making her dresses mostly without the aid of needles except what she carved out of bone. She laid aside one dress for eighteen years, to be worn when the white men should come, of which she had a presentiment. She built her own house, protected herself from the cold, gained supreme control over the wild beasts about her, and preserved her love for man and woman for well nigh two decades of human life alone in the wild. With no previous knowledge of civilization, without assistance to have educated her for it. An ordinary woman would have perished with dependency in such a desolate, hungry, naked, desolate outlook.